

INTRODUCTION TO COMMUNICATION SKILLS

INTRODUCTION TO COMMUNICATION

Introduction: Communication is a very important feature of all aspects of life. Every human being, regardless of occupation, responsibility, authority, station in life, age or gender needs to communicate. It is, therefore, necessary that we are able to communicate effectively.

Definition:

1. Communication is an **exchange of facts, ideas, opinions or emotions** by two or more persons (W.H. Norman & Summer)
2. Communication is **common understanding** through communion of minds and hearts.
3. The English word 'communication' is derived from a Latin word "communis" which means 'common'.
4. Communication is the **sharing of information**
5. Communication is the **giving and receiving of messages**
6. Communication is the **transfer of information** from one or more people to one or more other people
7. **Communication** is the activity of **conveying meaningful information**. Communication requires a sender, a message, and an intended recipient, although the receiver need not be present or aware of the sender's intent to communicate at the time of communication; thus communication can occur across vast distances in time and space. Communication requires that the communicating parties share an area of communicative commonality. The communication process is complete once the receiver has understood the message.
8. The process by which meaning is **exchanged between individuals through a common system** of symbols, signs, or behavior.
9. the **imparting or exchanging of information by speaking, writing**, or using some other medium:
10. the act or **process of using words, sounds, signs, or behaviors to express** or exchange information or to express your ideas, thoughts, feelings, etc., to someone else
11. **Two-way process of reaching mutual understanding**, in which participants not only exchange (encode-decode) information, news, ideas and feelings but also create and share meaning.
12. Any act by which one person **gives to or receives from another person** information about that person's needs, desires, perceptions, knowledge, or affective states. Communication may be intentional or unintentional, may involve conventional or unconventional signals, may take linguistic or nonlinguistic forms, and may occur through spoken or other modes."
13. The **process of sending and receiving messages** through verbal or nonverbal means--speech (*oral communication*), writing (*written communication*), signs, signals, or behavior.

Context - Communication is affected by the context in which it takes place. This context may be physical, social, chronological or cultural. Every communication proceeds with context. The sender chooses the message to communicate within a context.

Summary: No matter the type or mechanism of communication, every instance of communication must have **a message** that is being **transferred** from **sender to receiver**. In order for communication to be successful, the sender and receiver must have some signs symbols, words or signals in common with each other so the sent message can be understood. The ideal definition of communication **is a two-way interaction between two parties to transmit information and mutual understanding between themselves**. The interchange of

information from one party to another is best communicated when a discussion is available so the receiver can ask questions and receive answers to clarify the message.

Note: The terms '**Communication**' and 'effective **communication**' are distinctly different. One can communicate without effectively communicating the message. The main goal of communication is to ensure that there is effective communication.

PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION

Why communicate?

Effective communication is achieved when we speak, write or express ourselves through body actions; visual symbols to achieve the intended purpose. When we write, speak, persuade, inform, entertain, explain, convince or educate, we strive to achieve one or more of the following objectives:

- ✓ To be heard and to be understood
- ✓ To read and comprehend
- ✓ To be acceptable
- ✓ To have action taken

As noted above, we always have an objective when communicating. Effective communication will also enable you to:

- Get the job you want
- Boost your chances for promotion
- Help others get things done
- Benefit your business
- Improve your grades,
- Advance socially
- Ensure a bright future
- Enhance other skills
- Helping others get ahead

Successful and effective communication within an organization stems from the implementation of the communication process. All members within an organization will improve their communication skills if they follow the communication process, and stay away from the different barriers. It has been proven that individuals who understand the communication process will blossom into more effective communicators, and effective communicators have a greater opportunity for becoming successful.

Why Good Communication Skills? Good communication skills are skills that facilitate people to communicate effectively with one another. Effectual communication engages the choice of the best communications channel, the technical know-how to use the channel, the presentation of information to the target audience, and the skill to understand responses received from others. Self development, interpersonal skills, mutual understanding, mutual cooperation and trust are also important to set a complete channel of most effective and winning communication skills.

There are mainly three types of communication skills, expressive skills, listening skills and skills for managing the overall process of communication. The basic fundamental of all these types of communication is emotional

skills.

Expressive skills are required to convey message to others through words, facial expressions and body language. Listening skills are skills that are used to obtain messages or information from others. These help to clearly understand what a person feels and thinks about you or understand the other person closely. Skills for managing the overall process of communication help to recognize the required information and develop a strong hold on the existing rules of communication and interaction.

Importance of communication skills can never be ignored or neglected. These skills are the key to executing good management skills. With good management skills, you can have a team of members who together create an ambience of open communication, concise messages, probe for clarifications, recognize nonverbal signals, and mutual understanding. Good communication involves a set of complex skills.

The modern world today, calls for high scale effective communication skills in order to win the heavy competition in all spheres of life. For effective communication, a sender transmits his or her message in a clear and organized form to maintain and promote the need and interest of the receivers. Receivers or listeners show interest only if the person communicating is loaded with confidence, gestures and softness. Apart from management professionals, good communication skills are also required at all stages of life.

EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

Definition of Effective Communication

- ***Effective communication is a process through which the sender conveys a message that the receiver readily receives and understands. It is a two-way process instead of a one-way process.***
- A two way information sharing process which involves one party sending a message that is ***easily understood*** by the receiving party. Effective communication by business managers facilitates information sharing between company employees and can substantially contribute to its commercial success.

Effective communication is the process through which a message is passed to the intended recipient and it is understood by him or her, thus eliciting the required response. It involves the use of body language, gestures, listening skills and emotional awareness

What is the Importance of Effective Communication in Organizations?

The Importance of Effective Communication in organizations:

Effective communication is a basic prerequisite for the attainment of organisational goals. No organisation, no group can exist without communication.

Co-ordination of work is impossible and the organisation will collapse for lack of communication. **Co-operation** also becomes impossible because people cannot communicate their needs and feelings to others.

Every act of communication influences the organisation in some way or other. It is a thread that holds the various interdependent parts of an organisation together. When it stops, organisation activity ceases to exist. An idea, however great it is, is useless until it is transmitted and understood by others.

When communication is effective, it tends to encourage better performance and job satisfaction. People understand their jobs better and feel more involved in them.

It is through effective communication that an executive ultimately gets work done by others. Therefore, a successful executive must know the art of communication. Moreover, communication is a means whereby the employee can be properly motivated to execute company plans enthusiastically. It is the means by which behaviour is modified, change is effected and goals are achieved.

The first executive function is to develop and maintain a system of effective communication-the tool for understanding. It is commonly said that what nerves are to human organism, communications are to an industrial system.

Since management has been described as getting works done by people, it is necessary to communicate what the management wishes to accomplish by the various tasks which the organisation has undertaken.

Communication is also an intramanagement problem. It is the force that binds the people of an organisation together. Through communication they can attain a common viewpoint and understanding and co-operate to accomplish organisational objectives.

Good communication presupposes **a two-way flow of information** from the top down and from the bottom up (ie downward and upward communication). It can be compared to a mighty river on the banks of which business life is built.

McGregor sees all communication as a major factor in influencing others. All social interactions involve communication. In organisation communication is a two-way traffic whereby objectives, orders and policies are transmitted downward and desires and dissatisfactions are transmitted upward.

A successful executive should have the ability ***to receive, analyse and transmit information in motivating his subordinates in the right direction.*** Thus effective communication is a skill of management.

Communication is the link between knowledge and information. Possession of knowledge is of no use until it is converted into information. Hence, knowledge alone is not adequate for managerial success; what is required is knowledge plus ability to communicate accurately.

The popular saying 'knowledge is power' should be modified to 'applied knowledge is power.' And to apply, it requires effective communication.

In organisation communication transmits orders for work, aids in doing the work, buying raw materials and in advertising and selling the product. It is the means used to hire, fire, promote, praise, urge, censure, persuade and so on.

Communication plays a major role in dealing with employer employee relation problems, employee productivity, in short, with all human relations matters. Bad communication is often the root cause of many problems. Secrecy breeds rumours and a hush-hush attitude breeds harmful rumours.

As far as possible, management should supply all relevant information to employees. The employees of an organisation have great curiosity to know what the company is going to do with, say computers or bonus or DAs.

If the management does not provide information, the employees will concoct information through grape vine rumours which may have damaging results for the company. In order to avoid such problems, it is the duty of the management to supply all the relevant information through appropriate media at the right time.

Communication is not confined solely to employees. Management must communicate with its customers, owners, the community as well as its prospective and present employees. But our discussion is restricted to interpersonal communication and the organisational communication process.

Why Learn Effective Communication? The ability to communicate effectively is an art that can be used in many areas of your life, from employment and education to parenting and relationships. An effective communicator takes into account the audience or listener receiving the message and communicates accordingly.

Effectively Communicating Your Message To effectively communicate a message, you must understand how a receiver will process your message. It is important to include visuals, auditory effects as well as kinesthetic information (the interpretation of body language such as facial expressions and gestures — or, more formally, non-verbal behavior related to movement, either of any part of the body or the body as a whole) to appeal to the widest range of listeners.

Knowing Your Audience If you want to know details about your audience, send out a survey asking specific questions about age, interests, type of job performed, whether a parent or not. This information can assist you with formulating the message you will be sharing.

Paying Attention to Nonverbal Cues Effective communication means also paying attention to the nonverbal cues of the receiver. People who are listening attentively will often give you eye contact or a gesture such as a smile or a nod of the head to let you know they are listening.

Removing Barriers to Communication **Remove** barriers to communicating your message. For example, do not think about what happened right before you arrived to speak, whether it is a flat tyre or whether you received bad news. Focus all of your attention on the receiver and deliver the message in a way that he will understand.

Secret to Effective Communication in Organizations **Effective** communication in organizations drives better business results. People need to communicate effectively with each other to achieve positive results. Effective communication in organizations requires, first, the recognition that communication is critical and, second, a commitment to ensuring that everybody in the organization from the top down has the skills, tools and resources to communicate effectively. The following are some of the secrets to effective communication in organizations:

- (i) **Commitment from the Top** If there is one big secret to effective communication in organizations, it is that the commitment must come from the top. The CEO and senior leadership team set the expectation for effective communication through their commitment to **open, honest and timely communication**. Their actions, behavior and messages send a strong message to employees about the tone and tenor of communication in the organization. Without commitment from the top, even the most skilled of corporate communicators will be unsuccessful.
- (ii) **Positive Role Models** **Direct** supervisors and managers have the greatest influence and impact on employees. Managers who are trained in the use of effective communication with employees and

who serve as positive role models make a strong impression. Employees will emulate the style and tone in communication that they receive from their managers. Training, whether in-person, online or through resources such as books and journal articles, is essential. Few people are natural communicators; they need training and education to help them improve their communication skills.

- (iii) **Clear Expectations for Employees Organizations** should not assume that employees will know what is expected of them when it comes to communicating with each other, their subordinates or managers. Clear expectations conveyed in policies, handbooks and through direct communication can help employees avoid innocent mistakes that don't reflect company culture. Many rules of communication are unstated. For instance, is it alright for employees to go directly to department heads or their boss' boss with comments or questions? Is email preferred over face-to-face, or vice versa? The answers to these simple questions can help communication flow smoothly and avoid unnecessary misperceptions and frustrations.
- (iv) **Multiple Tools to Meet Varied Needs** because employees generally work in varying types of environments and have different jobs requirements and expectations, multiple options for communicating with and receiving communication from colleagues, managers and subordinates is important. Today's technology allows companies to offer both traditional types of communication - in-person, telephone, and newsletter and online options (such as teleconferencing/skype) for communicating with employees, as well as for two-way communication.
- (v) **Alignment and Consistency in Messages** Consistency and alignment in organizational communication is critical. Employees who hear different messages from supervisors than through company communications--for example, in newsletters or intranet sites--will be at best confused and, at worst, disillusioned. Carefully planned communication takes into consideration both the order and timing of communication to ensure that the right people hear the message first and to ensure that the right, and consistent, message flows effectively from the top to the bottom of the organization

The Value of Effective Communication in the Workplace Good communication provides many benefits in the workplace. Businesses consist of people working in conjunction to produce a product or offer a service. They also engage in interaction with customers, partners and other external organizations. Communication thus becomes vital to running an effective business -- and indeed some employees, particularly managers, do their job solely by acting as good communicators. The benefits of employees, managers and owners communicating effectively translate into huge rewards for the business itself.

- (a) **Saving Money** many businesses including state departments spend more than Ksh3 billion every year training their workers to write and communicate (read customer care) more effectively. A business can save such costs if employees already know how to communicate well. Communication speeds up the production process: informing managers of looming problems, and allowing coordinated responses to unforeseen situations. It allows salesmen to convey the benefits of the product or service to potential customers and secure sales more readily. Your employees work together more readily, which ensures smooth operation and in turn prevents time (and therefore money) lost needlessly.
- (b) **Securing Customers Communication** with potential customers means more than just explaining the benefits of the product or service. It means listening to the customers express their needs and the problems they wish to solve with your product. It also means gauging their satisfaction with the product, and determining any needs they might have for which your business can provide solutions. Communicating effectively with customers helps you retain their loyalty by meeting their needs... and more importantly, by treating them as valued people rather than walking objects/
- (c) **Esprit de Corps Communicating** effectively increases the bonds between employees. They feel more productive and don't become frustrated by managers or co-workers who don't understand what they're

saying. Furthermore, good communication helps employees understand their jobs better, and keeps them informed of the status on important projects. All of that helps create a more pleasant working environment, and fosters a sense of camaraderie among all the team members: reducing conflict and improving loyalty among employees.

- (d) **Global Marketplaces** We no longer live in a business world bound by a single language or culture. Components parts are made overseas, then shipped here for assembly, or U.S. products are shipped to other countries for sale. Communication allows your team not only to convey important details to overseas partners, but to understand the needs of both producers and consumers in other countries. Good communication lets you grasp cultural issues vital to properly marketing and selling a product; it also helps you express concerns and offer solutions in ways that overseas partners understand: reducing confusion and forging closer bonds.
- (e) **Team Building** Effective communication in the workplace helps employees and managers form highly efficient teams. Employees are able to trust each other and management. Effective communication reduces unnecessary competition within departments and helps employees work together harmoniously. The result of a team that works together is high productivity, integrity and responsibility. Employees know their roles on the team and know they are valued. Managers are able to correct employees' mistakes without creating a hostile work environment. A manager who openly communicates with his subordinates can foster positive relationships that benefit the company as a whole.
- (f) **Employee Morale** An improvement in employee morale can result from effective communication. Although pay is a concern for many workers, it is not their only concern. Employees appreciate good communication coming from management. It produces a healthy work environment. When employees are satisfied with their jobs, they are able to efficiently perform their duties with a positive attitude. Failing to communicate effectively in a workplace leads to frustration and confusion among employees. However, managers can alleviate such problems by keeping the lines of communication open.

Effects of Negative Communication in the Workplace:

Common elements of negative communication include rumors, misinformation, misinterpretation, incomplete information and employee slander. While many of the elements are purposely initiated -- for example, employee slander(grapevine) other elements occur without any intent of malice, such as unknowingly relaying incomplete information. Communication is essential for maintaining a productive workplace. By understanding the effects of negative communication in the workplace, you can develop policies that help to decrease the problem and encourage positive communication.

- (a) **Conflict.** A negative side effect to negative communication is workplace conflict. When one employee spreads false rumors about another staff member, the result can often be a verbal or physical altercation between the two parties. But conflict resulting from negative communication is often not that straightforward. For example, if an administrative assistant relays instructions from her manager that are incomplete, but she does not realize they are incomplete, then any anger resulting from the incomplete instructions would be directed at the assistant, but she would not understand why the conflict started.
- (b) **Morale.** Negative communication, whether intended or not, can have an effect on staff morale. Persistent intended negative communication can add stress to the workplace that makes it difficult to develop a productive work environment. Unintentional negative communication can be forgiven up to a point, but when it becomes habitual, it can lead to a drop in staff confidence in the company.
- (c) **Structure.** When there is a culture of negative communication in the workplace, it tends to have an effect on organizational structure. Communication between departments and other parts of the

company breaks down because the negative communication has degraded organizational communication to the point where it is no longer functional. This will leave departments and work groups on their own to answer their own questions and develop their own methods of getting the job done. In the end, the structure of the organization starts to break down.

- (d) **Recovery** An atmosphere of negative communication can be extremely difficult for a workplace to recover from. Intentional and unintentional negative communication erodes trust, and it pervades discourse to the point where information must be checked several times before it is acted upon. The longer negative communication is allowed to degrade the quality of communication and teamwork in the workplace, the longer it takes for the workplace to recover and become productive.

The Effects of Physical Environment on Communication in the Workplace

Whether it's apparent in obvious or subtle ways, the physical environment in your business workplace has an effect on the flow of communication. In addition to the setup and structure of the space, other factors invite or inhibit communication between you and your employees, from employee to employee and department to department.

- (a) **Obstacles to Communication Workplace** privacy encourages focus and concentration, but too much of it can create an obstacle when it comes to office communication. If the door and blinds in your office are always closed, it sends the message that you are unable or uninterested in communicating. Reserve closing off your office for important, private meetings or those times when you absolutely cannot be interrupted. When communication isn't possible, select a manager or someone else to be the gatekeeper so employees feel they can go to someone should problems arise.
- (b) **Furniture Placement for Group Work** Furniture arrangement plays a role in encouraging or discouraging communication. During team meetings or company-wide presentations where you want to encourage employee participation, the furniture arrangement can help you do this or make it difficult. A round table allows employees to see and communicate with each other, whereas sitting in rows limits communication to the people in the immediate area. If you want to encourage employees to focus on your presentation, engage them in an open discussion afterward, use a V-shape, theater-style seating arrangement. To find the most effective furniture arrangement, determine what type of communication you want to encourage and discourage.
- (c) **Noise in the Workplace** A breakdown in workplace communication can be related to noise levels. If your office space is above or next door to a business that runs heavy machinery, the noise can inhibit communication and productivity. Consider soundproofing wall, ceiling or floor materials for extremely loud levels of noise. Quieter noise levels that prove to be distracting can be blocked out with the use of white noise, such as your office heating and air conditioning or fan. Include employees in the discussion on how to solve the problem to find a solution that works for everyone.
- (d) **Using Color** The color of the walls and decor in your workplace can affect communication in your office. Dismal and dreary work spaces painted in institutional colors such as white or gray can have a negative effect on employee morale. If your business focuses heavily on creative tasks, incorporate bold colors with paint, wall decor or other accents to raise the positive feeling of the room. Business office spaces can be improved with the use of muted colors. A workplace atmosphere that feels positive encourages productivity and communication, while contributing toward morale, too.

How to Improve a Workplace Environment

The workplace environment affects how employees feel about their jobs and can influence their work habits. The physical environment is one factor that can affect employee productivity, but the way staff members interact and how they are treated also play a role in the overall work climate. Whether you notice a decline in

employee performance or you want to take a proactive approach to prevent problems, approach changes to the environment gradually and focus on the biggest areas of need in your office.

Step 1 Walk through the workplace to inspect the physical environment. Look for outdated, broken or dangerous equipment and workstations that need to be fixed or replaced. Make a list and start working on those improvements.

Step 2 Meet with employees to determine areas for improvement in the workplace. Look for suggestions on physical improvements as well as improvements on staff relations and management practices. Review the list with other managers after the meeting to determine the feasibility of implementing the ideas.

Step 3 Inspect workstations to make sure they are ergonomic. Chairs should provide adequate support through the backrest and armrests while allowing employees to slide their legs under desks. Employees should be able to adjust their computer monitors and keyboards to use them comfortably.

Step 4 Replace light fixtures that don't work well. Add more task lighting to work areas. Position desks near windows to utilize the natural sunlight

Step 5 Rearrange furniture to create more functional work areas based on the type of work and collaborations that take place in the office. Give employees personal workspace along with areas for meetings and collaborative work.

Step 6 Add color to the walls with artwork. Hang a bulletin board that highlights employee achievements, birthdays and other employee-related information. Invite employees to get involved in decorating the walls and contributing to the bulletin board displays.

Step 7 Develop a sense of community in the workplace by getting employees more involved in work-sponsored activities. Take an interest in the personal lives and interests of employees. Schedule family night activities at a local park, sports complex, restaurant or similar venue to allow staff members to get to know one another outside the workplace.

Step 8 Incorporate team-building activities at the office if employees struggle to work together. Hold workshops on working as a team.

Step 9 Base your company policies and goals on mutual respect and a sense of fairness. Be consistent when applying policies, dispensing punishments and implementing rewards so you don't create division or jealousy among staff members.

ELEMENTS OF COMMUNICATION

For effective communication to take place, the following elements **MUST** be present:

- **Sender:** The sender initiates communication
- **Message:** The message is what the sender communicates to the receiver
- **Channel:** This is the means used to transmit the message from the sender to the receiver.
- **Receiver** – the recipient of the message
- **Feedback:** this is the response the sender gets from the receiver

Communication Situations: Communication situations are often classified in either of the following:

- (a) **Formal Communication:** Formal communication situations typically have a determined set of behavior that is expected of communicators. They are usually characterized by how people are expected to behave, dress, the manners they are expected to display and what they discuss. This means there are set rules that must be strictly followed.
- (b) **Informal Communication:** Informal communication has fewer or no rules and, of course, very few expectations. Informal communication occurs without any planning and in many cases outside the formal circles. Discussions, clothing are more relaxed and a wide range of unplanned topics are covered.

****Formal and Informal Communication Channels are discussed elsewhere***

PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication is a process that involves two parties – the sender and the receiver. This means that communication is a two-way process. It, basically involves the sender and the receiver.

STAGES IN THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS

STAGE 1: CONCEIVING THE MESSAGE The first stage in the communication process is the decision made by a sender to communicate a message, such as a scream of fright or gasp of pain. Others are the result of an impulse which occurs so quickly that the sender is barely conscious of having decided to say or do anything.

+The sender has the need to communicate a message. this could be as a result of (a) impulse, (b) thought process (c) external stimulus/reflex action (where sender is barely conscious of it eg. a shout.

STAGE 2: ENCODING THE MESSAGE Before the message is sent to the recipient, the sender needs to encode it in an appropriate language. The language may take the form of an abrupt gesture of impatience or a carefully written letter or report. It may also take the form of a picture, symbol or non-verbal expression or gesture. The languages of communication include the following:

- The spoken word (oral)
- The written word
- The number
- The picture, drawing or symbol or
- The non-verbal communication – expression, gesture
- Posture

The eventual success of the message depends on the choice of an appropriate language.

+when the sender is ready with the message, then it is ready for transmission (sending the message). Therefore, it is up to the sender to make sure that the message accurately reflects what is intended and is then presented in the most suitable format. – Clarity of purpose, message and delivery are essential elements of effective communication.

STAGE 3: SELECTING THE COMMUNICATION CHANNEL A channel is a *vehicle/medium* by which the message is passed on to the audience. For you to select/choose an appropriate channel, ask yourself: Am I going to communicate by use of words, pictures or both? Which medium would be the most appreciated by the audience – written or spoken, a letter or personal chat?

Once the language has been chosen, the sender needs to select a medium through which to transmit the message. The choice of medium depends upon a number of, sometimes quite complicated factors. If the message is disciplinary, then a formal, private interview may be required.

Some messages must be written – contracts are an obvious example – and geographical distance may require that the message is transmitted in letter-form. Sometimes the very complexity of a message dictates that it is

produced as a written report which may be composed and studied in stages. Alternatively, the need for a quick exchange of attitudes and opinions may suggest a meeting as the best medium.

+once the sender has encoded and is ready to send the message, he/she has to choose the appropriate medium/channel to do this: this could be the following: **face-to-face** – meetings, interviews, presentations, informal discussions etc; **oral** – using telephone, cell phone, voice mail, answering machines etc; **written**- using letters, memos, reports, forms, fax messages, text messages or e-mail etc; **visual**- using charts, tables, diagrams, slides, maps or notices etc.

The likely effect of a message upon its receiver will also influence the choice of medium. Bad news, for example, is much better broken in a private interview than more impersonally in a letter

STAGE 4: DECODING THE MESSAGE. Before a message can be absorbed or acted upon, it first needs to be understood. Many messages are ineffective because the sender failed to realize that the language he had chosen was beyond the ability of his receiver to comprehend. Terms like ‘burn it’ and ‘jargon’ are frequently employed when someone has used inappropriate language. Some of the reasons for failure by a receiver to decode a message successfully are:

+ **Interpreting the Message:** the receiver ensures that he/she understands the underlying as well as the explicit meaning e.g. a received message may conceal a hidden meaning – message to be read ‘between the lines’. The receiver must interpret the message correctly as intended by the sender.

1. The receiver does not share the sender’s language
2. The sender’s jargon (words or phrases) is unknown to the receiver. When we used words, we should always remember the following:
 - Words mean different things to different people
 - Words mean different things to the same person at different times
 - The word is not the thing – it is merely a symbol to represent the thing
 - We can never communicate to another person exactly that we think and feel
3. The sender is a specialist and the receiver is layman
4. Education, cultural pursuits and outlooks create a language block between sender and receiver.
5. Ensure that your chosen language is fully comprehensible to the receiver. Put yourself in his or her position. Try to ascertain your receiver’s abilities and limitations.
6. Take care that your message is not capable of being misinterpreted. Avoid vagueness or ambiguity.
7. Check that you are receiving the desired feedback – answers, confirmations, indications or attitudes.

AS A RECEIVER:

1. Give the incoming message all your attention. Avoid being side-tracked or distracted
2. Check that the sender’s chosen communication **medium** is meeting your needs. Help the sender to put his message across effectively by letting him know tactfully if the medium is inappropriate.
3. Ensure that you **comprehend** the message fully. Seek confirming feedback from the sender if the message is not clear by asking for explanations or repeats.
4. Take care to **interpret** the message correctly. Check whether there is any underlying or implied meaning in the message.
5. Avoid the temptation deliberately to *misinterpret* a message as a means of retaliating against its sender. If you are not on good terms, endeavour to thrash the matter out of goodwill.
6. Provide the sender with sufficient **feedback**. Reassure him that you have received and understood the message.

5 **FEEDBACK**

It is important that the receiver sends feedback to the sender. The receiver, therefore, however how busy, must take immediate steps to provide feedback. This could be in the form of signals passed to the sender – eg. Written reply, spoken word or person to person communication. By sending back the feedback, the process starts again

There are quite a number of problems that may occur at different stages during the process and it is important to know this. They include:

- Message ill-conceived/vague/ambiguous
- Message encoded in wrong language, inappropriate tone
- Use of wrong medium, time wasting, expensive, no written record
- Receiver unable to comprehend sender's language, use of jargon/vocabulary unfamiliar to receiver
- Message wrongly interpreted, poor relationship between receiver and sender
- Feedback not given or interpreted wrongly

Noise or interference (barriers) in different stages can affect the delivery of the message. This can interfere with the encoding and decoding stages. Any kind of interruption that distracts or distorts the message from being understood correctly or clearly is considered as noise. E.g. dressing, religious, affiliations, aroma or even stench.

Importance of Feedback. **Feedback** has a great role in the organizational point of view also. There are lots of ways in which company takes feedback from their employees, such as: Employee surveys, memos, emails, open-door policies, company news letter etc. Employees are not always willing to provide feedback. The organization has to work a lot to get the accurate feedback. The managers should encourage feedback by asking specific questions, allowing their employees to express general views, etc. The organization should be receptive to their employee's feedback.

Static communication creates a vacuum. The speaker assumes the message is received but has no feedback from the listener. This lack of feedback means the speaker fails to modify the message to help the listener better understands the speaker's attitude and position. When businesses fail to create open feedback channels, they operate in a communication vacuum. Management and owners can't improve their messages to employees, and workers aren't able to ask questions about operations or make suggestions for business improvement.

In general, we can quantify the following importance of feedback in communication, either in a formal or informal setting.

1. It completes the whole process of communication and makes it continuous.
2. It sustains communication process
3. It makes one know if one is really communication or making sense
4. It is a basis for measuring the effectiveness of communication
5. It is a good basis for planning on what next to be done especially statistical report
6. Communication will be useless without feedback
7. Feedback paves way for new idea generation

The basis being established here is that, feedback is the livewire of communication as communication is the livewire of human existence and interaction. The process of communication finishes only when the vicious

cycle ends up with feedback. Thus, feedback should be carefully considered before being put forward due to its significance.

SUMMARY In summary we note that communication is a two way process that takes place through several stages which include: conception, decoding, comprehension, interpretation and feedback. Hence:

1. **Conception** of the message happens when an idea, thought or feeling is formulated in the mind of the sender as a result of an external or internal stimulus or due to motivation. At this stage, the sender decides on the nature of the message.
2. **Encoding** of the message involves giving the message a communication form. This may be verbal or non-verbal.
3. **Channel** – the sender selects the most appropriate and effective vehicle that will deliver the message to the receiver. The media may include telephone, fax, letter, mouth etc.

*It is only after careful selection of the most appropriate medium/channel that effective communication will be achieved. The following are general factors to consider when selecting/choosing the most appropriate channel to use:

- (a) **Cost** (time & money): *the channel selected should be cost-effective in terms of time and money.*
- (b) **Speed**: *the urgency of the message is important. The channel selected should be appropriate to deliver the message within the expected time.*
- (c) **Audience**: *The medium selected should be one that can serve the communication needs of the target audience, in terms of age, education background among others.*
- (d) **Availability**: *the medium selected should be available both to the sender and receiver. A television may not be the most appropriate medium to send a message to people living in places where electric power is not available.*
- (e) **Message**: *the message will dictate the type of channel to be used in a particular situation, the complexity, urgency, the purpose of the message.*
- (f) **Confidentiality**: *Different messages require different levels of confidentiality especially in today's world where technology has made great strides.*
- (g) Complexity of the message.

Other factors

- Potential effectiveness
- Need for fact
- Simultaneous reception of information by recipients
- Need for a written record
- Need for instant feedback
- Time
- Cost

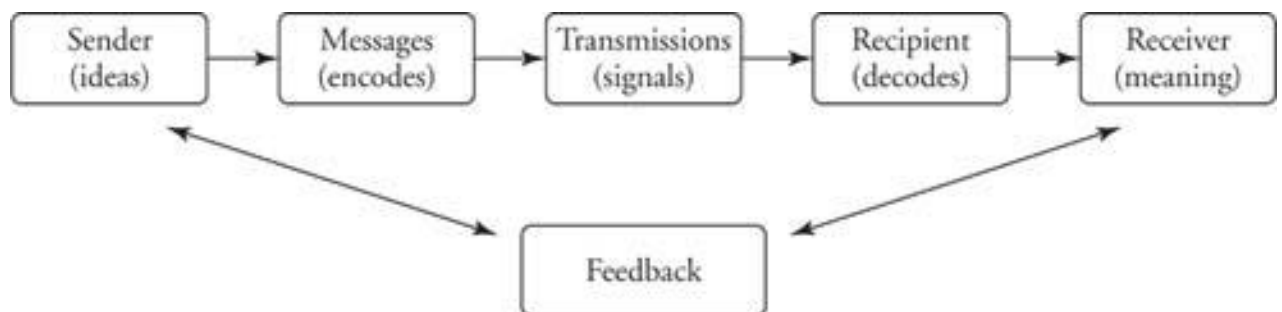
4. **Transmission:** the message is transferred to the receiver through the selected channel. At this stage, there is possibility of the message being interfered with by “noise”
5. **Reception:** this is the physical act of receiving the message through any of the six senses – the sense of hearing, touch, taste, sight and smell.
6. **Decoding:** this involves the receiver trying to assign meaning to the language used. This is done by relating the language to the knowledge of terms and vocabulary. Comprehension takes place when the receiver tries to spend moments to absorb the meaning and understand the technical jargon used by the sender.
7. **Interpretation** is similar to what is loosely termed as ‘reading between the lines’. This means that you as the receiver should search for the underlying meaning.
8. **Feedback:** this involves reacting to the message received. The message is encoded and a response is given in a language that the sender can understand. The communication process is then complete when the message is transmitted back to the originator of the message (that is the sender). The receiver goes through the same communication process as the sender had done. Only when this cycle is completed, can communication be said to have been effective.

SELECTED MODELS OF COMMUNICATION

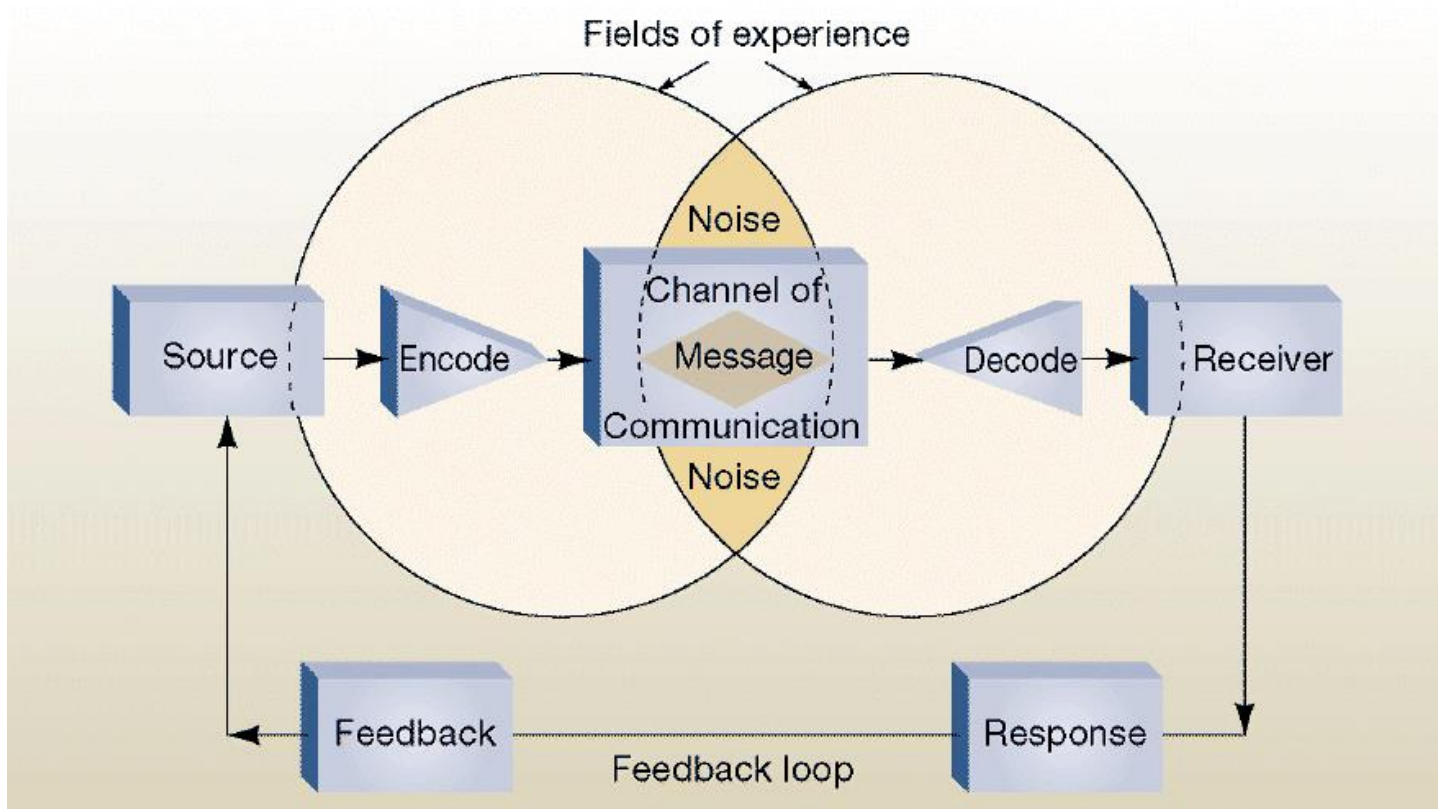
The nature of the communication process can be defined through models which have been done by various scholars over the years.

The goal of communication is to convey information—and the understanding of that information—from one person or group to another person or group. This communication process is divided into three basic components: A *sender* transmits a message through a *channel* to the *receiver*. (Model 1 shows a more elaborate model.) The sender first develops an idea, which is composed into a message and then transmitted to the other party, who interprets the message and receives meaning. Information theorists have added somewhat more complicated language. Developing a message is known as *encoding*. Interpreting the message is referred to as *decoding*.

MODEL 1

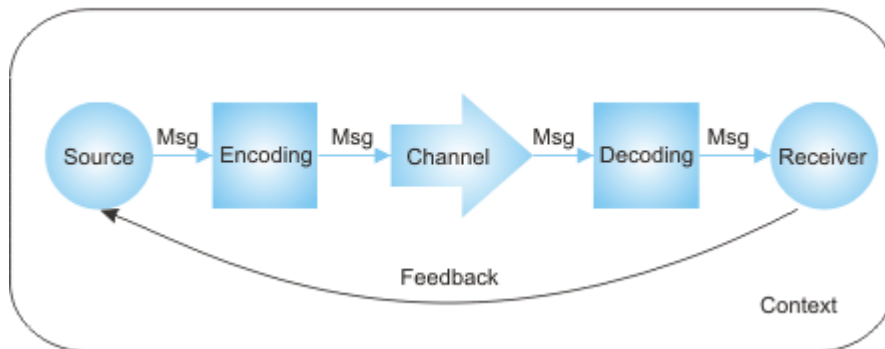


MODEL 2



MODEL 3

The Communications Process



MODEL 4 BERLO'S MODEL



The communication process is initiated by the 'sender' who communicates a message through a channel (sign, symbol, code, register, etc) which is capable of being understood and interpreted by a receiver.

Simply, the cycle of communication proceeds through a number of stages during which a message is conceived by a sender, encoded and transmitted via a particular route to a receiver who then decodes and interprets it and finally confirms that it has been understood. The message should always be seen in the CONTEXT (the time or place – environment when communication occurs). A message may not be received if **noise** is available in

the channel (noise is anything that blocks or hinders the reception of the intended interpretation of the message or feedback).

PRINCIPLES OF COMMUNICATION

A principle is that which guides. The following are normally considered as the 7Cs of communication (Each starts with the letter 'C')

1. Correctness: To be correct in communication the following principles should be borne in mind.

1. Use the correct level of language
2. Include only facts words and figures
3. Maintain acceptable writing mechanics
4. There should be proper grammar punctuation spelling and paragraphing

2. Conciseness: Business executives are normally busy. They don't have time to go through unnecessarily lengthy messages. The writer is also a loser if he writes wordy messages because it involves more time and money to type and read. Conciseness makes the message more understandable and comprehensible

1. Eliminate wordy Expressions.
2. Include only relevant material.
3. Avoided unnecessary Repetition.

3. Clarity: Clarity demands that the message should be correct, concise, complete, concrete and with consideration

1. Use the right level of language
2. Proper punctuation makes the writing clear
3. Check Accuracy of fact figure & Words

4. Completeness: The message should be complete to bring desirable results. It should include everything the reader needs for the reaction you desire. You must know what information our reader wants or needs You should be able to know the reader's background, viewpoint, needs, attitudes and emotions.

1. Provide all necessary information.
2. Answer all questions asked.
3. Give something Extra, when Desirable.\

5. Concreteness: The business writing should be specific definite unambiguous and vivid rather than vague and general. The following guidelines lead to concreteness.

1. Use specific facts and figures
2. Put action in your verb
3. Choose vivid image building words.

6. Consideration: Consideration refers to you attitude sympathy the human touch and understanding of human nature. Consideration means the message with the receiver in mind. You should try to visualize your readers, their desires, problems , emotions, circumstances and possible reaction to your request.

1. Focus on you instead I & We
2. Show reader benefit or interest in reader
3. Emphasize

7. Courtesy: Courtesy is more important and advantageous in business writing than it is in face to face communication or conversation. Courteous message strengthen present relations and make new friends. It is a goodwill building.

1. Answer your mail promptly
2. Be sincerely tactful thoughtful and appreciative
3. Use expressions that show respect

BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

***(Also see the notes above on the communication process – there are some barriers stated)**

These are the factors that cause problems for communication – they hinder the clear interpretation and reception of message. In some situations, they are known as **blockers**

We must be aware of them if we are to overcome them or communicate in such a way as to minimize their effect.

There are many reasons why interpersonal communications may fail. In many communications, the message (what is said) may not be received exactly the way the sender intended. It is, therefore, important that the communicator seeks feedback to check that their message is clearly understood.

The skills of Active Listening, Clarification and Reflection may help but the skilled communicator also needs to be aware of the barriers to effective communication and how to avoid or overcome them.

There are many barriers to communication and these may occur at any stage in the communication process. Barriers may lead to your message becoming distorted and you therefore risk wasting both time and/or money by causing confusion and misunderstanding. Effective communication involves overcoming these barriers and conveying a clear and concise message.

CATEGORIZATION OF BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION

1. Language Barriers (Linguistic Barriers): When communicating in the same language, the terminology used in a message may act as a barrier if it is not fully understood by the receiver(s). For example, a message that includes a lot of specialist jargon and abbreviations will not be understood by a receiver who is not familiar. Clearly, language and linguistic ability may act as a barrier to communication. However, even with the terminology used, regional colloquialisms and expressions may be misinterpreted or even considered offensive.

2. Psychological Barriers. The psychological state of the receiver will influence how the message is received. For example, if someone has personal worries and is stressed, they may be preoccupied by personal concerns and not as receptive to the message as if they were not stressed. Stress management is an important personal skill that affects our interpersonal relationships.

Anger is another example of a psychological barrier to communication, when we are angry it is easy to say things that we may later regret and also to misinterpret what others are saying. More generally people with low self-esteem may be less assertive and therefore may not feel comfortable communicating - they may feel shy about saying how they really feel or read negative sub-texts into messages they hear.

3. Physiological Barriers. Physiological barriers may result from the receiver's physical state: for example, a receiver with reduced hearing may not grasp to entirety of a spoken conversation especially if there is significant background noise.

4. Physical Barriers. An example of a physical barrier to communication is geographic distance between the sender and receiver(s). Communication is generally easier over shorter distances as more communication channels are available and less technology is required. Although modern technology often serves to reduce the impact of physical barriers, the advantages and disadvantages of each communication channel should be understood so that an appropriate channel can be used to overcome the physical barriers.

5. Systematic Barriers. Systemic barriers to communication may exist in structures and organisations where there are inefficient or inappropriate information systems and communication channels, or where there is a lack of understanding of the roles and responsibilities for communication. In such organisations, individuals may be unclear of their role in the communication process and therefore not know what is expected of them.

6. Attitudinal Barriers. Attitudinal barriers are behaviour or perceptions that prevent people from communicating effectively. Attitudinal barriers to communication may result from personality conflicts, poor management, resistance to change or a lack of motivation. Effective receivers of messages should attempt to overcome their own attitudinal barriers to facilitate effective communication.

The following are some specific barriers to effective communication:

- (a) **Differences in Perception:** eg people of different ages, nationalities, cultures, education, occupation, sex, status, personality etc - each have different perceptions. Thus, differences in perception are often the root of many of other barriers to communication. **Perceptual Bias/Different Perceptions:** Selective hearing eg avoids listening to what is unpleasant or what did not fit him/her pre-existing attitudes and values. Communication does not easily take place between people who have different perceptions. Eg. An employee listening to his manager talk about the importance of team work and its benefits but is not comfortable in the team would likely 'block' the message.
- (b) **Jumping to Conclusions:** "see what we expect to see, hear, what we expect to hear" rather than what is being said.
- (c) **Stereotyping:** treating all people as if they were the same. Thus, danger of discussing people and what they say/communicate. A good example is taking a whole community/religious group to be the same if there is one who has done wrong.
- (d) **Lack of Knowledge:** It is difficult to communicate effectively with someone who has a very different background from yours, or whose knowledge of the particular subject of discussion is considerably less than yours.
- (e) **Lack of interest:** The receiver's lack of interest in your message. Do not assume that everyone is as concerned about our interests as we are.
- (f) **Difficulties in Self-Expression:** Communicator has difficulty finding the words to carry ideas. This also goes with lack of confidence.
- (g) **Emotions:** Any strong felt emotion of either receiver or communicator can also prove to be a serious barrier.

- (h) **Personality:** Differences in people's personality can cause problems. Often our resulting behavior can then affect the behaviour of the other person eg the issue of 'clash of personalities' is one of the most common causes of communication failure. Strong influences against personalities may make one accept or reject what is being said with due consideration.
- (i) **Poor Listening Skills:** for example, a group/audience/receiver who is not used to sitting down and concentrating – therefore, message is not successfully communicated thus resulting in an inappropriate feedback.
- (j) **Information Overload:** this results from giving too much details, facts in a very short period of time. This would mean that most of the message would not be communicated successfully.
- (k) **Lack of Interest/Hostile attitude:** this occurs when an individual believes that the message being communicated is not for him/her, is a waste of valuable time, then the person's message will not get through
- (l) **Lack of Understanding:** using 'big' words or unfamiliar words to the audience/receiver that they do not understand, words with symbolic meaning, different interpretations will lead to misunderstanding.
- (m) **Poor Timing:** The message must be delivered at the right time. Eg. Telephoning at lunch time and Friday afternoons may make it difficult to get through because the person you need is not available.
- (n) **Noise:** This is any sound/anything that is unwanted which interrupts a communication channel. The noise could be either:
 - . **Technical:** eg. Interference on a mobile phone or fax not working
 - o **Physical:** too much activity in the area where communication is taking place
 - o **Psychological:** increased anxiety may interfere with ability to pay attention to the other speaker.
- (o) **Appearance of the Individual:** this may hinder communication if the audience is critical. A speaker with a dirty outfit/who is poorly dressed may not receive the favourable response from the audience.
- (p) **Distraction:** any upsetting factor which influences the human senses such as strong light/strong smell will hinder effective communication.
- (q) **Mistrust:** when the parties in the business of communicating do not trust one another and there is no goodwill. Effective communication will be hindered.
- (r) **Distance:** distances are factors in communication. When the place to be communicated to is very far/the people are far apart, weak signals may not reach easily. Therefore communication is hindered. However, the effect of distance can be countered by information technology where satellite disks can be used for long distance communication.
- (s) **Geographical Features:** these can hinder communication in that mountains, rivers, ranges, valleys, lakes and oceans do separate people/area and again this can easily be overcome through modern technology.
- (t) **Different Status:** communication takes place easily between people with different status within the organization/school etc. (rich-poor etc)

OVERCOMING COMMUNICATION BARRIERS

Unless we overcome the barriers that make us not communicate, more barriers will be created. The following are some of the ways of overcoming the barriers:

- (i) **Face-to-Face:** This will allow for constant adjustment of the message to ensure that the message is received well.
- (ii) **Being sensitive** to the other person's/people's backgrounds. Eg. Where the person grew, tribe, culture, language and level of education.

- (iii) **The use of direct, simple** and unambiguous language while taking care of words with symbolic meaning.
- (iv) **The use of frequent repetition;** restatement and reinforcement/follow-up to ensure the message is properly understood.
- (v) **Being supportive** to counter any defensive attitude – continued support will help the communication process
- (vi) **Being a good listener:** this will encourage the communicator to continue giving the message.
- (vii) **Put away any mistrust,** prejudice bias and misunderstanding to ensure you communicate and interpret the message clearly.
- (viii) **Using appropriate channels** of communication that keeps the noise levels low
- (ix) **By developing interest** in the subject of communication and preparing oneself for the same.
- (x) **By using modern technology** methods which enables not only faster communication but also over great distances and geographical barriers.

Conclusion: the above stated are only a few of the many factors which can cause communication to be less effective or even fail completely. It is up to either the receiver of the communication/sender to make conditions as satisfactory as possible so that communication – a far from perfect process stands a chance of being effective.

ESSENTIALS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

For communication to take place, there are those items that must be available (those that cannot be done away with). The following are such essentials:

- (a) **The Subject:** the subject is also known as the content of the message. This is the information that you would like your receiver to understand. Ask yourself of the following questions before you send the message or initiate the process of communication:
WHAT exactly do you want to say?
What exactly do you need to say?
What does your audience want to know?
- (b) **The Audience:** This is the receiver of the message. It is important to have enough information about the audience. For example, you need to know their personality, age status, education, political inclinations, marital status etc. it is important to gauge how they are likely to react to the content of your message.
- (c) **Purpose** of Communication: this requires that you ask yourself the following questions:
 - (i) Why am I communicating?
 - (ii) What is my real reason for writing, speaking or gesticulating?
 - (iii) What do I hope to achieve? Is it to change the attitude of the audience, or change their opinion?
 - (iv) What do I want the audience to do as a result of my communication? In other words, do I want to persuade, inform, influence, educate, advise, entertain, provoke, stimulate thought or castigate?

- (d) **Appropriate Channel:** A channel is a vehicle by which the message is passed on to the audience. For you to select/choose an appropriate channel, ask yourself: Am I going to communicate by use of words, pictures or both? Which medium would be the most appreciated by the audience – written or spoken, a letter or personal chat?
- (e) **Proper Presentation/Packaging:** This the means by which you will achieve the most desired response from the audience. Ask yourself: what is the best way to organize the points you want to drive home to your audience? What words should you use to create the right effect? How will you use stress and intonation to deliver the message appropriately?

CHANNELS OF COMMUNICATION

A channel is a vehicle/medium by which the message is passed on to the audience. In official circles, information is normally passed through two channels. These are formal and informal. **Workplace** communication is the process of exchanging information, both verbal and non-verbal, within an organization. An organization may consist of employees from different parts of the society. In order to unite the activities of all employees, communication is crucial. Communicating necessary information to the entire workforce becomes necessary. Effective workplace communication ensures that all the organizational objectives are achieved.

1. Formal Communication

Formal communication - written or oral - follows the chain of command of the formal organization; the communication flows from the manager to his immediate subordinates. Each recipient then re-transmits the message in the selected form to the next lower level of management or to staff members, as appropriate. The message progresses down the chain of command, fanning out along the way, until all who have a need to know are informed. Formal communication also flows upward through the organization on the same basis.

Formal communication normally encompasses the transmittal of goals, policies, instructions, memoranda, and reports; scheduled meetings; and supervisory-subordinate interviews.

How does an organization chart aid formal communication?

Formal communication refers to interchange of information officially. The flow of communication is controlled and is a deliberate effort. This makes it possible for the information to reach the desired place without any hindrance, at a little cost and in a proper way. This is also known as ‘Through Proper Channel Communication.’

Characteristics

Following are the chief characteristics of the formal communication:

- (1) Written and Oral: Formal communication can both be written and oral. Daily works are handled through oral communication, while the policy matters require written communication.
- (2) Formal Relations: This communication is adopted among those employees where formal relations have been established by the organisation. The sender and the receiver have some sort of organisational relations.
- (3) Prescribed Path: The communication has to pass through a definite channel while moving from one person to another. For example, to convey the feelings of a worker to the manager, the foreman’s help has to be sought.
- (4) Organisational Message: This channel is concerned with the authorised organisational messages only and the personal messages are out of its jurisdiction.
- (5) Deliberate Effort: This channel of communication is not established automatically but effort has to be made for its creation. It is decided keeping in view the objectives of the organisation.

Advantages

- (1) Maintenance of Authority of the Officers: Formal communication maintains constant relations among the superiors and the subordinates as a result of whom the dignity of the line superiors is maintained. Consequently, it is convenient to control the subordinates and fix their responsibility which is absolutely needed for effective and successful control.
- (2) Clear and Effective Communication: In formal communication, there is a direct contact among the managers and the subordinates. Both understand the capability, habits, feelings, etc. of one another. Managers know as to when and under which conditions their subordinates need information. In this way, this communication is capable of making available timely information. Hence, it is clear and effective.
- (3) Orderly Flow of Information: The information has to pass through a definite route from one person to another. Hence, the flow of information is systematic.
- (4) Easy Knowledge of Source of Information: In this type of communication, the source of each information can be easily located.

Disadvantages/Limitations

- (1) Overload of Work: In a modern business organisation much information, many messages and other things have to be communicated. Under formal communication, they are routed through a definite channel and this consumes much of the time of the superiors and thus some other important works are left unattended.
- (2) Distortion of Information: This method can be a hindrance in the flow of information. Sometimes the distance between the sender and the receiver is so big that the information has to pass through many hands and by the time it reaches the receiver it is distorted. Thus it fails to serve its purpose.
- (3) Indifferent Officers: The officers do not pay much attention to the suggestions and complaints of the subordinates. In such a case a subordinate may come lose his faith in the effectiveness of communication.

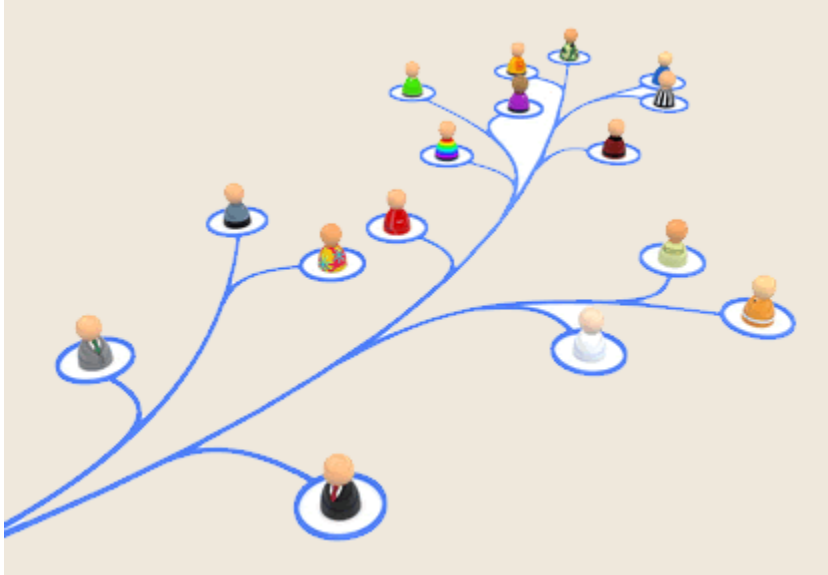
2. Informal Communication (aka Grapevine Communication)

No organization operates in a completely formal or structured environment. Communication between operations depicted in an organizational chart do not function as smoothly or as trouble-free as the chart may imply. In most organizations operating effectively, channels of communication have developed outside the hierarchical structure.

The informal communication process supplements the formal process by filling the gaps and/or omissions. Successful managers encourage informal organizational linkages and, at the same time, recognize that circumvention of established lines of authority and communication is not a good regular practice. When lines of authority have been bypassed, the manager must assume responsibility for informing those normally in the chain of command of the action taken.

There is a fine line between using informal communications to expedite the work of the organization and the needless bypassing of the chain of command. The expediting process gets the job done, but bypassing the chain of command causes irritation and can lead to hard feelings. To be effective, the manager must find a way to balance formal and informal communication processes.

Grapevine Communication



The "grapevine" is a part of the unofficial communication process in any organization. A grapevine arises because of lack of information employees consider important: organizational changes, jobs, or associates. This rumor mill transmits information of highly varying accuracy at a remarkable speed. Rumors tend to fall into three categories: those reflecting anxiety, those involving things hoped for, and those causing divisiveness in the organization. Some rumors fade with the passing of time; others die when certain events occur.

Employees take part in the grapevine process to the extent that they form groups. Any employee not considered a part of some group is apt to be left out of this unofficial communication process.

The grapevine is not necessarily good or bad. It serves a useful function when it acts as a barometer of employees' feelings and attitudes. Unfortunately, the information traveling along the grapevine tends to become magnified or exaggerated. Employees then become alarmed unnecessarily by what they hear. It is imperative that a manager be continually alert to the circulation of false information. When discovered, positive steps should be taken to provide the correct information immediately.

Informal communication is also called grapevine communication because there is no definite channel of communication. Under it some information passes through many individuals and covers a long distance making its origin obscure. This is exactly like a grapevine where it is difficult to find the beginning and the end.

Characteristics

Informal or grapevine communication has the following characteristics:

(1) Formation through Social Relations:

This communication is born out of social relations who mean that it is beyond the restrictions of the organisation. No superior-subordinate relationship figures therein. A more sociable superior can gather much information through this channel.

(2) Two types of Information: Through this communication, information about the work and the individual can be collected.

(3) Uncertain Path: Since it is beyond the restrictions of the organisation, it follows no definite channel. Like a grapevine, it moves in a zigzag manner.

- (4) Possibility of Rumour and Distortion: Responsibility for the true or false nature of communication does not lie on any individual and, therefore, not much attention is paid to its meaning while communicating. Consequently, the rumours keep floating.
- (5) Quick Relay: Informal communication makes news spread like wildfire. Not only this, people start adding something of their own which sometimes changes the real meaning of the communication.

Advantages

The informal channel of communication has the following advantages:

- (1) Fast and Effective Communication:** Under this communication, the messages move fast and their effect is equally great on the people.
- (2) Free Environment:** Informal communication is done in a free environment. Free environment means that there is no pressure of any office-big or small. The reactions of the employees can easily be collected.
- (3) Better Human Relations:** Informal communication saves the employees from tension. Freedom from tension helps the establishment of better human relations. This also affects the formal communication.
- (4) Easy Solution of the Difficult Problems:** There are many problems which cannot be solved with the help of formal communication. There is more freedom in informal communication which helps the solution of difficult problems.
- (5) Satisfying the Social Needs of the Workers:** Everybody wants good relations with the high officers at the place of his work. Such relations give satisfaction to the employees and they feel proud. But this can be possible only with the help of the informal communication.
- (6) Grapevine channels carry information rapidly.** As soon as an employee gets to know some confidential information, he becomes inquisitive and passes the details then to his closest friend who in turn passes it to other. Thus, it spreads hastily.
- (7) The managers get to know the reactions of their subordinates on their policies.** Thus, the feedback obtained is quick compared to formal channel of communication.
- (8) The grapevine creates a sense of unity among the employees who share and discuss their views with each other. Thus, grapevine helps in developing group cohesiveness.**
- (9) The grapevine serves as an emotional supportive value.**
- (11) Present grievance:** Under the informal system the employees disclose their needs, sentiment and their emotions to others authority without feeling any hesitation.
- (12) Alternate system:** The management sometimes does not able to reach all information by formal system. Informal system covers the gap or familiarity of formal system.
- (13) Improved relationship:** Any problem between the workers and the management can be solved by informal system. So it makes good relationships among the employees and the management.
- (14) Increase efficiency:** Under the informal system, the employees discuss their problem openly and they can solve it. For this, the work is done properly and it develops the efficiency of the employee.
- (15) Providing recommendation:** In this system the employees inform their superior about their demands, problem and the way to develop the implementation system of the work. As a result it creates an opportunity to send the recommendation to their management.
- (16) Flexibility:** Informal communication is more flexible than formal communication because it is free from all type of formalities.
- (17) Rapid communication:** Informal communication transmits very fast. Especially miss-information or rumor spread rapidly to others in the organization.
- (18) Improve interpersonal relationship:** Cooperation and coordination in informal communication leads to improve interpersonal relationship which is very much essential to carry out the business activity smoothly.
- Others:** Improve labor management relationship. Free flow of information. Remove mental distance. Evaluation of employees. Obtain immediate feedback. Reliving frustration. Increasing efficiency. Solution of problems and helping decision-making. Enhance mutual trust etc.

Disadvantages/Limitations

The disadvantages of informal communication are as follows:

- 1. Unsystematic Communication:** This communication is absolutely unsystematic and it is not necessary that information reaches the person concerned.
- 2. Unreliable Information:** Most of the information received through this communication is undependable and no important decision can be taken on its basis.
- 3. Distort meaning:** Something the meaning and the subject matter of the information is distorted in this system.
- 4. Spread rumor:** In this system, the miss-information or rumor spread rapidly. The original information may be transformed to wrong information.
- 5. Misunderstanding:** Under this system, generally, the employees do not obey the formal authorization system. So it creates the opportunity to develop misunderstanding.
- 6. Maintaining secrecy is impossible:** In informal communication system maximum communication is made by open discussion. So it is impossible to maintain the secrecy of the information.
- 7. Difficulty in controlling:** Under informal communication system no established rules or policy is obeyed. So it is very much difficult to control the information.
- 8. Non-cooperation:** Informal communication system sometimes develops the adversary culture among the employees. So they are not to be cooperative with each other and their efficiency may be reduced.

Others: Providing partial information. Not reliable. No documentary evidence. Damaging discipline. Contradicting to formal information etc. Others: Providing partial information. Not reliable. No documentary evidence. Damaging discipline. Contradicting to formal information etc.

-The grapevine is a supplement in those cases where formal communication does not work. The grapevine carries partial information at times as it is more based on rumours. Thus, it does not **clearly depict the complete state of affairs**. The grapevine is **not trustworthy** always as it does not follow official path of communication and is spread more by gossips and unconfirmed report. The productivity of employees may **be hampered as they spend more time talking** rather than working. The grapevine leads to **making hostility against the executives**. The grapevine may **hamper the goodwill** of the organization as it may carry false negative information about the high level people of the organization.

* A smart manager should take care of all the disadvantages of the grapevine and try to minimize them. At the same time, he should make best possible use of advantages of grapevine.

TYPES OF COMMUNICATION (Communication Flows in Organizations)

VERTICAL COMMUNICATION

Vertical Communication is of the following two types:

i) Downward Communication:

The communication by top hierarchy with their subordinates is called downward communication. This communication includes orders, rules, information, policies, instructions, etc. The chief advantage of the downward communication is that the subordinates get useful timely information which helps them in their work performance,

Downward communication usually deals with job instructions, directives, policies, guidelines rationale, information and feedback. Downward communication is a supervisory communication, which is initiated by the upper management. It flows downward through the hierarchy of command. The effective downward communication is crucial to the success of the organization. The management or the supervisory staff has to communicate with the subordinates in order to organize, coordinate and direct the operational aspects of the organization. It is a very suitable channel to the organization in which the 'chain of command' is arranged in the ranks that are distinctly one below the other

Medium for Downward Communication: Oral media dominates the downward flow of communication. It is convenient for a departmental head to give oral instructions and orders to the supervisor. Instead of issuing lengthy written instructions, the Managing Director usually convenes a meeting of the departmental managers in order to impart the essential directives or to gather their suggestions on various issues. Yet, the management may use both oral and written media of downward communication. There are various alternatives of communication media at the disposal of every management. Some typical alternative devices of communication are **letters, circulars, memos, company journals, video and audio recordings, telephone calls, meetings, face-to-face conversations, speeches to the employees and the posters.**

The objective of Downward Communication. The superiors communicate with their subordinates with the objective that the employees may do their work with accuracy, neatness, sincerity, steadiness, thoroughness, honesty and punctuality. They give specific **directives or instructions** to the employees that clarify the ways and procedures of job performance. They expect that the employees should maintain the standards of work quality. The employee is instructed with the view that he does not commit mistakes in his operative or supervisory works.. When the superiors over communicate with the subordinates, the balance of handling the messages is disturbed. The major cause of message overload is the increasing complexity of business life.

Downward Flow of Communication: Communication that flows from a higher level in an organization to a lower level is a downward communication. In other words, communication from superiors to subordinates in a chain of command is a downward communication. This communication flow is used by the managers to transmit work-related information to the employees at lower levels. Employees require this information for performing their jobs and for meeting the expectations of their managers.

Downward communication is used by the managers for the following purposes:

- i. Providing feedback on employees performance
- ii. Giving job instructions
- iii. Providing a complete understanding of the employees job as well as to communicate them how their job is related to other jobs in the organization.

- iv. Communicating the organizations mission and vision to the employees.
- v. Highlighting the areas of attention.

Organizational publications, circulars, letter to employees, group meetings etc are all examples of downward communication. In order to have effective and error-free downward communication, managers must: Specify communication objective, Ensure that the message is accurate, specific and unambiguous and Utilize the best communication technique to convey the message to the receiver in right form.

ii) Upward Communication.

This is quite the reverse of the downward communication. This flows from the subordinates to the superiors. The subject-matter of this communication includes suggestions, reactions, reports, complaints, etc. This sort of communication helps the superiors in taking decisions.

Upward Flow of Communication: Communication that flows to a higher level in an organization is called upward communication. It provides feedback on how well the organization is functioning. The subordinates use upward communication to convey their problems and performances to their superiors.

The subordinates also use upward communication to tell how well they have understood the downward communication. It can also be used by the employees to share their views and ideas and to participate in the decision-making process.

Upward communication leads to a more committed and loyal workforce in an organization because the employees are given a chance to raise and speak dissatisfaction issues to the higher levels. The managers get to know about the employees feelings towards their jobs, peers, supervisor and organization in general. Managers can thus accordingly take actions for improving things.

Grievance Redressal System, Complaint and Suggestion Box, Job Satisfaction surveys etc all help in improving upward communication. Other examples of Upward Communication are -performance reports made by low level management for reviewing by higher level management, employee attitude surveys, letters from employees, employee-manager discussions etc.

2. HORIZONTAL COMMUNICATION (ALSO KNOWN AS LATERAL)

This is communication that takes place at same levels of hierarchy in an organization is called lateral communication, i.e., communication between peers, between managers at same levels or between any horizontally equivalent organizational members.

Horizontal communication is used by the same level officers to solve the problems of similar nature and profit by the experience of other people. The subject-matter of horizontal communication includes information, requests, suggestions, mutual problems and coordination-related information.

Advantages of horizontal communication are as follows:

- ✓ It is time saving.
- ✓ It facilitates co-ordination of the task.
- ✓ It facilitates co-operation among team members.
- ✓ It provides emotional and social assistance to the organizational members.
- ✓ It helps in solving various organizational problems.
- ✓ It is a means of information sharing
- ✓ It can also be used for resolving conflicts of a department with other department or conflicts within a department.

DIAGONAL COMMUNICATION

Communication that takes place between a manager and employees of other workgroups is called diagonal communication. It generally does not appear on organizational chart. For instance - To design a training module a training manager interacts with an Operations personnel to enquire about the way they perform their task.

EXTERNAL COMMUNICATION.

Communication that takes place between a manager and external groups such as - suppliers, vendors, banks, financial institutes etc. For instance - To raise capital the Managing director would interact with the Bank Manager.

FORMS OF COMMUNICATION

1. Verbal Communication- **Verbal Communication** is divided into:
 - Oral Communication
 - Written Communication
2. Nonverbal Communication
3. Visual (audio-visual)

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication refers to the form of communication in which message is transmitted verbally; communication is done by word of mouth and a piece of writing. Objective of every communication is to have people understand what we are trying to convey. **In verbal communication remember the acronym KISS** (keep it short and simple).

When we talk to others, we assume that others understand what we are saying because we know what we are saying. But this is not the case. Usually, people bring their own attitude, perception, emotions and thoughts about the topic and hence creates barrier in delivering the right meaning.

So in order to deliver the right message, you must put yourself on the other side of the table and think from your receiver's point of view. Would he understand the message? How would it sound on the other side of the table?

Oral Communication In oral communication, Spoken words are used. It includes face-to-face conversations, speech, telephonic conversation, video, radio, television, voice over internet. In **oral communication**, communication is influenced by pitch, volume, speed and clarity of speaking.

Advantages of Oral communication are:

It brings quick feedback. In a face-to-face conversation, by reading facial expression and body language one can guess whether he/she should trust what's being said or not. Other advantages include:

- There is high level of understanding and transparency in oral communication as it is interpersonal.
- There is no element of rigidity in oral communication. There is flexibility for allowing changes in the decisions previously taken.
- The feedback is spontaneous in case of oral communication. Thus, decisions can be made quickly without any delay.
- Oral communication is not only time saving, but it also saves upon money and efforts.
- Oral communication is best in case of problem resolution. The conflicts, disputes and many issues/differences can be put to an end by talking them over.
- Oral communication is an essential for teamwork and group energy.
- Oral communication promotes a receptive and encouraging morale among organizational employees.
- Oral communication can be best used to transfer private and confidential information/matter. (not always)

Oral communication (such as speech) is not frequently used as legal records except in investigation work. *The advantages of oral channels of communication are that they:*

- are fast - useful for obtaining very recent unpublished information
- are based on two-way communication and therefore promote an understanding of the real *information need(s)* and the communication of *relevant* information
- are flexible
- simplify and facilitate the transmission of information between people working in different subject areas (useful in interdisciplinary studies)
- are easy and pleasant to use
- Its easy and simple and saves a lot of money because oral communication is the less expensive way to communicate with each other.
- It allows feedback on the spot so if the receiver is not 100 percent sure what the message meant, then that feedback will be answered right away.
- Because the message is instantly, it helps in avoiding time wasted.
- It brings personal warmth and friendliness and develops a sense of bonding because of these contacts between the people.

Disadvantages of oral communication

In face-to-face discussion, user is unable to deeply think about what he is delivering. Other disadvantages include:

- Relying only on oral communication may not be sufficient as business communication is formal and very organized.
- Oral communication is less authentic than written communication as they are informal and not as organized as written communication.
- Oral communication is time-saving as far as daily interactions are concerned, but in case of meetings, long speeches consume lot of time and are unproductive at times.
- Oral communications are not easy to maintain and thus they are unsteady.
- There may be misunderstandings as the information is not complete and may lack essentials.

It requires attentiveness and great receptivity on part of the receivers/audience

- Unrepeatable
 - Information retention is difficult, it is harder to store or retrieve. The 80-20 rule comes into play here-the majority of the audience is likely to forget 80% of the information, while retaining only 20%- thus making the speaker's task very difficult.
 - Selective hearing, receiving information may be distorted resulting in miscommunication.
- Some of the disadvantages of the oral communication are:
- There is no instant feedback between the messenger and the receiver and that the messages could be misunderstood.
 - Long and wordy type of communication cannot be as effectively as written messages.
 - The receiver might understand the message differently.
 - Responses on the spot might not be carefully thought of.
 - More or less or a different meaning might be conveyed by manner of speaking, tone of voice and facial expressions
 - Audience must be active listeners.
 - The same words said in different tones may convey very different messages.
 - Difficulty in finding words to correctly convey meaning in a short period of time.
 - Some may find it easier to organise information through writing.
 - Easier to visualise the flow of information? This idea is good but only if the visualisations, eg. ppt presentations, are kept simple, short and to the point for the audience to grasp the idea easily. Presentation of too much written material is difficult to grasp in a short span of time.
 - People usually take more time to communicate an idea.
 - Sometimes the audience need to ask questions to clarify, this often happens in lectures.
 - NATO (No Action Talk Only)

*Effective delivery via oral communication but lacks any followup actions. We cannot blindly trust the speaker by what He/She says or claims, Actions speaks louder than Words.

- are not open to everyone - established researchers have access to good networks of contacts, but these usually take time to cultivate
- can lead to misconceptions because the information is sometimes incomplete (lack of detail etc.)
- are difficult to maintain and therefore unstable
- it can also lead to misbelief, as oral promises do not lend anywhere
- as a human nature one can make mistake in spelling something different which can sometimes leads to major mistake

Written Communication

In written communication, written signs or symbols are used to communicate. A written message may be printed or hand written. In written communication message can be transmitted via email, letter, report, memo etc. Message, in written communication, is influenced by the vocabulary & grammar used, writing style, precision and clarity of the language used.

Written Communication is most common form of communication being used in business. So, it is considered core among business skills.

Memos, reports, bulletins, job descriptions, employee manuals, and electronic mail are the types of written communication used for internal communication. For communicating with external environment in writing, electronic mail, Internet Web sites, letters, proposals, telegrams, faxes, postcards, contracts, advertisements, brochures, and news releases are used.

Advantages of written communication includes:

1. Messages can be edited and revised many time before it is actually sent.
2. Written communication provides record for every message sent and can be saved for later study
3. A written message enables receiver to fully understand it and send appropriate feedback.

Disadvantages of written communication includes:

1. Unlike oral communication, written communication doesn't bring instant feedback.
2. It takes more time in composing a written message as compared to word-of-mouth. and number of people struggles for writing ability.

Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication is the sending or receiving of wordless messages. We can say that communication other than oral and written, such as **gesture, body language, posture, tone of voice** or **facial expressions**, is called nonverbal communication. **Nonverbal communication is all about the body language of speaker.**

Kinesic Communication Kinesic communication is communicating by body movement and is perhaps the most well-known non-verbal form of communication, although it is not the only way to talk with others without words.

Body posture The way that the body is held can communicate many different messages.

An open body that takes up a lot of space can indicate comfort and domination, whilst a closed-in body that makes itself small can signal inferiority.

Copying of the other person's body shows agreement, trust and liking.

Gestures

Gesture is communicating through the movement of body and arms.

Ekman and Friesen (1969) identified five types of gesture:

- Emblems: Direct replacements for words.
- Illustrators: Shaping what is being said.
- Affect displays: shows of emotion.
- Regulators: for controlling the flow of conversation.
- Adaptors: Self-oriented tension relievers and other forms.

Facial signals

When we communicate with others, we look mostly at their face. This is not a coincidence as many signals are sent with the 90-odd muscles in the face. The way the head tilts also changes the message.

The eyes are particularly important, and when communicating we first seek to make eye contact. We then break and re-establish contact many times during the discussion.

Eyebrows and forehead also add significant signals, from surprise to fear to anger.

The mouth, when not talking can be pursed, downturned or turned up in a smile.

Nonverbal communication helps receiver in interpreting the message received. Often, nonverbal signals reflects the situation more accurately than verbal messages. **Sometimes nonverbal response contradicts verbal communication** and hence affect the effectiveness of message.

Nonverbal communication has the following three elements:

Appearance

Speaker: clothing, hairstyle, neatness, use of cosmetics

Surrounding: room size, lighting, decorations, furnishings

Body Language

facial expressions, gestures, postures

Sounds

Voice Tone, Volume, Speech rate

Visual Communication:

"It is easier to see with your eyes than with your mind."

- Visual communication is a more concrete way of communicating where pictures and text are often used together. You can use illustrations, photos, sketches, symbols, and texts. This is a way of communicating that becomes more specific and doesn't allow for misunderstandings to the same degree as the spoken language. That's why we use contracts or manuals when we want to be extremely clear and completely avoid misunderstandings.

Visual communication as the name suggests is communication through visual aid and is described as the conveyance of ideas and information in forms that can be read or looked upon. Visual communication in part or whole relies on vision, and is primarily presented or expressed with two dimensional images, it includes: signs,

What Are The Benefits? /Advantages of Visual Communication

- (a) **Immediacy** One of the primary benefits from visual communication over verbal is immediacy. Think back to the last time you tried to explain something complex to a friend, coworker, family member, more often than not in these situations you spend long periods of time making sure your audience understands what it is you're explaining. Now, contrast that experience with looking at a chart explaining the sales for a specific product, you can show that information almost instantaneously. Visual Communication can bring a thing, location and even an idea to life in dynamic ways.
- (b) **Simplicity** Another advantage is simplicity. Often visual communication can simplify the information of ideas that you are seeking to pass on to others. For example, architects use visual diagrams and schematics to pass on valuable information to contractors in a quick, easy to understand manner. Visual communication can also demonstrate the relationship between two entities or ideas in accessible ways.
- (c) **Flexibility** Visual communication can also be more flexible in many ways than verbal communication. Visual communication not only bridges geographic distances, it can span cultural references. If you are looking to appeal to a broad demographic audience, such as a television or cable audience, visual images may allow you to reach more people with your message. Appealing visual images will often be more persuasive than verbal pitches.

Disadvantages/Limitations of Visual Aids

- If a visual aid is not properly designed for its intended use and audience, it can lead to a breakdown in communication. For example, a business person presenting a new product launch must consider the size and color of the product images he wants to show to the audience. The size of his audience determines the size of the pictures he will present. A large audience requires large images that might be shown on a screen so they are visible by everyone. A small audience, such as one that can be seated around a conference room table, can be shown images from a brochure.
- A visual aid with the wrong information can cause a distraction and detract from the message the image is supposed to convey. For example, a discussion of a company's manufacturing plants might be accompanied by a map showing the location of these plants within their respective

- counties. . But if you include irrelevant information, such as tourist sites, it can distract the audience from the purpose of the map – to show the location of manufacturing plants.
- sometimes the speaker relies too much on the visuals and doesn't present the material as well as they could,
 - If a visual aid is not properly designed for its intended use and audience, it can lead to a breakdown in communication.

Audio-visual communication

It involves the use of what one can see and hear as well. This can be seen in films, power point presentations, television presentations – news/bulletins etc. To employ audio-visual aids in communication enhances communication at all spheres.

Next time you are trying to convey large, complex information to a group of people think about the advantages of doing so visually. This way you will be certain that your audience will leave with a solid understanding of what you're trying to convey. Also, you will be saved from frustration when you're forced to repeat yourself to make you point better understood. typography, drawing, graphic design, illustration, colour They are an aid to understanding but should never be used as a substitute for the presenters input. A presentation should consist of a speaker backed by visual aids and not vice-versa. As aids to the presentation it is best practice to incorporate them once the content planning phase is complete. Design your messages first, then review your cue cards and decide where audio-visual aids can be used to add clarity. Remember the word visual; audiences like to see models, diagrams, charts, pictures and so on. However text is not popular, so try to keep the written word off your visual aids.

How to Use Audio-Visual Aids

Audio-visual aids can be used in any of the following ways: /

Advantages of Audio Visual Aids in Communication

- > To reinforce stated facts
- > To aid the understanding of ideas
- > To clarify relationships or physical layouts
- > To introduce the audience to a new topic area

Useful guidelines to consider when designing visual aids include:

1. Use graphs to highlight a comparison.
2. Use line charts to highlight a trend.
3. Keep the visual device clear – avoid unnecessary clutter.
4. Use meaningful titles to avoid ambiguity.
5. Use colors carefully – they must be clear under all lighting conditions

Commonly Used Audio-Visual Aids

The following audio-visual aids are all commonly used to enhance presentations: Handouts, flipcharts, whiteboards, slide shows, projectors, illustrations, computer graphics, audio tapes, videos, multimedia, physical objects, 3D models. Audio-visual aids have varying degrees of complexity and more than one type can be combined to create a sophisticated presentation. However, this may create a distance between the presenter and audience - who may be left with an overriding impression of a very fancy show but who may have missed your message.

Additional Notes.....

Classification of Communication

FORMAL Vs INFORMAL COMMUNICATION

Communication could be verbal – spoken or written, or non-verbal i.e. using sign language, body movements, facial expressions, gestures, eye contact or even with the tone of voice. In an organization, there are two channels of communication – formal communication and informal communication.

Someone said correctly “The very attempt of, not to speak, speaks a lot. “Communication plays a crucial role in our life, as people interchange their ideas, information, feelings, opinions by communicating. **Formal communication** is one that passes through predefined channels of communication throughout the organization. The communication follows a hierarchical chain of command which is established by the organisation itself. In general, this type of communication is used exclusively in the workplace, and the employees are bound to follow it while performing their duties. On the contrary, **Informal communication** refers to the form of communication which flows in every direction, i.e. it moves freely in the organization and does not follow any pre-defined channel for the transmission of information. This type of communication moves freely in all directions, and thus, it is very quick and rapid. In any organization, this type of communication is very natural as people interact with each other about their professional life, personal life, and other matter.

Comparison Chart: Formal Vs Informal Communication

Basis for Comparison	Formal Communication	Informal Communication
Meaning	A type of verbal communication in which the interchange of information is done through the pre-defined channels is known as formal communication.	A type of verbal communication in which the interchange of information does not follow any channels i.e. the communication stretches in all directions.
Another Name	Official Communication	Grapevine communication
Reliability	More	Comparatively less
Speed	Slow	Very Fast
Evidence	As the communication is generally written, documentary evidence is present.	No documentary evidence.
Time Consuming	Yes	No
Advantage	Effective due to timely and systematic flow of information.	Efficient because employees can discuss work related problems, this saves time and cost of the organization.
Disadvantage	Distortion due to long chain of communication.	Spread of rumors
Secrecy	Full secrecy is maintained.	It is difficult to maintain the secrecy.

Basis for Comparison	Formal Communication	Informal Communication
Flow of Information	Only through predefined channels.	Can move freely.

Formal Communication.

Example: Requests, commands, orders, reports etc.

The formal communication is of four types:

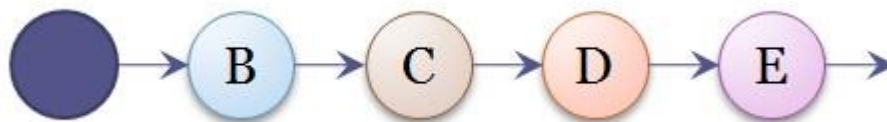
- **Upward or Bottom-up:** The communication in which the flow of information goes from subordinate to superior authority.
- **Downward or Top-down:** The communication in which the flow of information goes from superior to subordinate.
- **Horizontal or Lateral:** The communication between two employees of different departments working at the same level.
- **Crosswise or Diagonal:** The communication between the employees of two different departments working at different levels.

Informal Communication

Example: Sharing of feelings, casual discussion, gossips, etc.

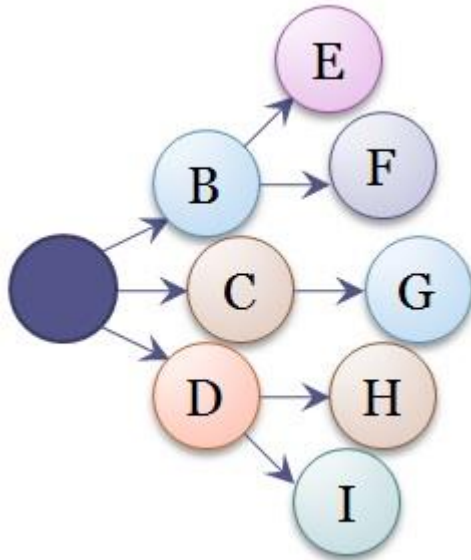
The informal communication is of four types:

- **Single Strand Chain:** The communication in which one person tell something to another, who again says something to some other person and the process goes on.



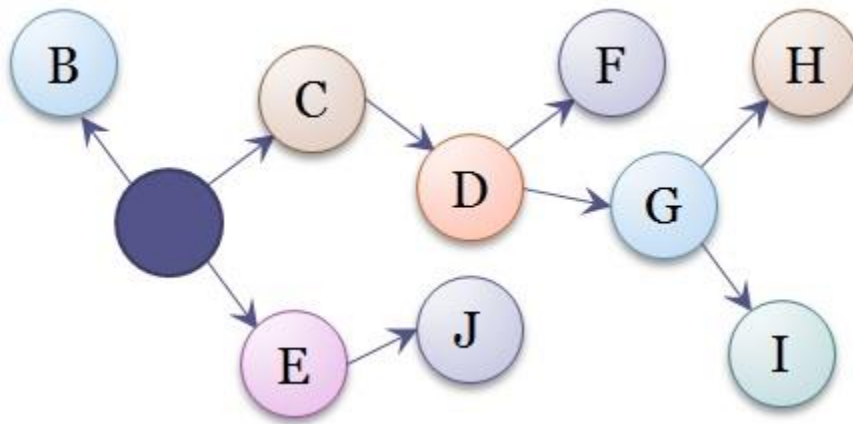
Single Strand Chain

- **Cluster Chain:** The communication in which one person tells something to some of its most trusted people, and then they tells them to their trustworthy friends and the communication continues.



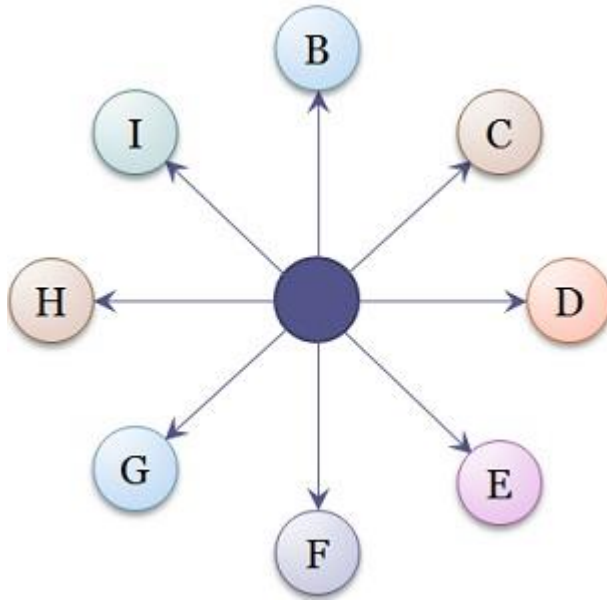
Cluster Chain

- **Probability Chain:** The communication happens when a person randomly chooses some persons to pass on the information which is of little interest but not important.



Probability Chain

- **Gossip Chain:** The communication starts when a person tells something to a group of people, and then they pass on the information to some more people and in this way the information is passed on to everyone.



Gossip Chain

Conclusion

Nowadays, many big Transnational Organizations has started an open-door policy, in which any employee of any department can communicate directly with the head of an organization, about their complaints, grievances, and requests. This results in reducing the complexity of the formal communication.

INTERNAL Vs EXTERNAL COMMUNICATION

Internal communication refers to the **communication** strategies inside the company among employees and company leaders. It is also the transmission of information between organizational members or parts of the organization. i.e. communication between executives, managers, and junior employees. Clearly-defined policies should be written out and all employees should know what their duties and responsibilities are when it comes to communicating with their colleagues, superiors or outside parties.

External communication occurs between those within the company and those in the outside world. i.e. communication with an organization's clients;- press, competitors, shareholders, customers, suppliers, or other business owners. Common examples of external business communications include direct mailings, financial records, press releases, and newsletters.

The important differences between internal and external communication are as follows:

Basis	Internal communication	External communication
1.Purpose	Main purpose is to exchange information of various departments and division of the organization.	It is done mainly for maintaining relationship with external parties.
2.Types	Two types: Vertical and Horizontal communication.	No such classification.
3.Frequency	It occurs frequently in performing organizational activities.	It occurs less frequently than internal communication.
4. Distance	No significant distance between sender and receiver.	Significant distance exists between sender and receiver.
5. Coverage	Its coverage is limited within the organization.	Its coverage is broad with external bodies.

The Importance of Internal & External Communication

1. **Internal communication** controls all internal operations of an organization.
2. **Team building**

Effective internal communication policies can help improve overall employee morale and team work. When employees attend regular face-to-face meetings or brainstorm in person with their colleagues, they tend to stay connected to one another as opposed to being alienated or isolated in their individual jobs. When employees are all on the same page about goals, client projects or changes in the company, they can operate more effectively as a unit. A good internal communications plan can help staff stay focused, motivated and on track.

3. Company Identity

Internal communication is also necessary in order to maintain a clear company identity. A company must know its own goals, values and strengths before it can communicate these traits to the consumer or to stakeholders. Internal communication assists employees in understanding company culture and helping them learn key messaging about what the company wants to convey to the public. Over time, this type of messaging becomes second nature to employees and helps them to convey a unified, well-defined image of what the company stands for.

4. Reputation

External communication is critical during times when a company's reputation needs defending or strengthening. When a company can communicate honestly, candidly and intelligently to the consumer or the public, it can strengthen its own reputation. External communication policies must be in place to address problems or concerns that can arise within the company or about a company

product. If the company can build a good reputation with the press, too, it is more likely to be conveyed in a positive light.

5. Public Relations

Although many companies focus on sales as a measure of business success, public perception is just as important to the organization's bottom line. **External communications** are one way to shape and define a corporation's image to the community, clients, and potential investors. External communications such as newsletters, media stories and press releases let the public know about the company workplace, philanthropic and environmental efforts, and other image-related activities, all of which serve to strengthen the public relations efforts of a company.

6. Leadership

Thought leadership is another important reason for **external communication**. A company should be able to convey to the press or to the consumer why it is a leader in the industry. For example, advertisements and press releases about the company need to clearly explain the value of a service or product. External communication strategies can position the company as a leader in a particular field. That reputation can often help the company improve sales or beat out competitors.

Limitations

- Marketing budget.

The main disadvantage in **external communication** would be the marketing budget. The person has to spend and invest to communicate about his business. It can also create and makes the competition stronger. The competitors would be more conscious on what we do. Missing information or mistakes in the content can cause negative impacts. So we have to more and more focused and conscious.

- Public backlash.

While traditional print methods of communications are still common, modern technology has changed the face of external communications, and the Internet has become a valued resource in reaching new customers. Companies create websites to let people know of upcoming products and services. Social media such as Facebook and blogs are an easy way to reach target demographics and are a cost-effective means of promotion. However, with interactive technology there is also the possibility of public backlash, such as negative comment posting. In the long run, the benefits far outweigh the risks, as technology is far-reaching and allows the company to communicate with audiences all over the world.

-The public impression of an organization can define the success or failure of the company in the long-run. One misplaced quote, or badly worded newsletter will not only ruin an expensive external communications plan, but also has the potential to affect corporate revenue. Therefore, those in charge of external communications for the company need to be aware of their audience and the company image they wish to convey.

Limitations in Internal communication

- Conflict is one major internal communication disadvantages. Some employees may use the internal communication benefits to argue with each other or with the management. Conflict can result in tension and disruption of operations.
- Waste of Time. Employees can spend the whole day exchanging office gossip or rumor mongering. Even though it is important to implement internal communication, proper systems should be used to ensure information shared by employees is for the benefit of the organization.
- Performance Reviews. Performance reviews are mostly used by management as an internal communication system to discuss personal goals and employees challenges. However, some employees sufficient information may not be obtained as some employees may fear disciplinary actions or warnings.

Other advantages of Internal Communication

Motivation - When internal communication is well implemented, it motivates the employees of an organization. Internal communication generally provides a good relationship among senior staff and subordinates. It is only through communication that every member can feel as part of the organization. This acts as a motivating factor.

Control - The most important function in any organization is control. However, with active internal communication systems, control is very possible.

Coordination - To achieve set goals in any organization, coordination among all departments is needed. A company cannot run smoothly without coordination.

Job Satisfaction - When an organization has a sound internal communication, all employees feel happy and job satisfaction is kept. When an employee is satisfied, an impact will be seen on performance.

Running an Organization - For smooth operations of the organization, internal communication should be well implemented. To make it, the organization can utilize professional and powerful internal communication software like ez Talks Meetings.

Source of Information - Reliable information is needed for a business to survive in the market. This means that only through sound internal communication that an organization can supply such information to the right department at the right time.

Turnover - One of the benefits of good internal communication is that when internal communication systems are working properly, company expenditure reduces significantly.

Aid in Decision Making - Contribution of employees in decision making will not only increase the quality of decisions made, but also ensure those decisions are well implemented.

Joint Trust - For an organization to run smoothly and for higher productivity, there must be trust between employees and the management. Only through internal communication that joint trust can be achieved.

Proper Supervision - Proper supervision cannot be achieved if managers or supervisors fail to understand the problems of the employees. Upward and downward communication can be well exercised if internal communication is effective.

The motivation of All Employees - To motivate the employees, management must understand the attitude of the employees. With continuous internal communication, proper motivation can be provided.

Develop Managerial Efficiency - To run an organization effectively and efficiently, a supervisor or a

manager must be aware of the resources of the organization. Such information can only be provided through internal communication.

Exchange of Ideas - The last one of the benefits of internal communication is that when internal communication is well utilized, employees are able to share ideas and their views, develop communication skills, maintain a link between various departments, and increase efficiency.

INTERPERSONAL Vs INTRAPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

Intrapersonal communication is the process of sensing, thinking, perception, evaluating and interpreting events within the self-mind of an individual. For intrapersonal communication, different persons may respond differently to a single message because of differences in their perception and thinking.

Intrapersonal Communication

Knowing yourself is the beginning of all wisdom.
—Aristotle

The ability to hold internal conversations is unique to humans. These conversations are an internal nonverbal form of regular speech, and this ability exists naturally in all individuals. What varies from person to person is the degree to which a person has honed this ability in order to benefit oneself. Such a skilled nature of communication helps in one's self-development.

People with highly developed intrapersonal skills are proficient at examining themselves and identifying their own weaknesses and strengths and focusing on them. This allows them to view themselves as a behavioral entity. Such awareness engenders a intuitive, adaptive, and independent nature. Examples of such evolved individuals can be found throughout history, and they include eminent people such as Mother Teresa, Mahatma Gandhi, Socrates, Joan of Arc, Martin Luther King Jr., Abraham Lincoln, etc. All these individuals exhibited and applied their refined intrapersonal communication skills to causes that would help in the betterment of society. But there is a flip side to every quality, and this skill set is no exception. Despite its many advantages, it exhibits certain disadvantages too.

On the other hand, **Interpersonal communication** occurs when two individuals are involved or exchanging information, ideas, opinions, feelings relating to the personal, social, organizational, national and international matter who are located in the same place.

It is the face-to-face exchange of thoughts and feelings between people, but it can also include other forms of communication, like instant messaging, exchanging email messages, and "talking" via online chat rooms. What's important is that each communicator responds to the other as a "you," not as an "it."

The important differences between interpersonal and intrapersonal communication are as follows:

Basis	Intrapersonal communication	Interpersonal communication
1. Meaning	Interpersonal communication occurs when a person communicates with himself or herself.	Interpersonal communication is the exchange of information, ideas, opinions etc. between two persons.
2. Nature	It happens in the form of sensing, thinking, perception, evaluating and interpreting within oneself.	It happens in the form of exchanging and sharing of information or ideas between two persons.
3. Person involved	Only the communicator involved in intrapersonal communication.	Two persons are involved in interpersonal communication.
4. Media	It does not require any media or channel.	Must use verbal or non-verbal media.
5. Information flow	Information does not go beyond person's mind.	Information goes from one's mind to another mind.
6. Visibility	It is invisible.	It is visible in nature.

Intrapersonal Communication

Advantages and disadvantages

PROS	CONS
Self-awareness It allows the person to be aware of every aspect of their own personality. Through introspection, the person becomes aware of the qualities that help shape his personality which in turn makes him aware of his motivations, aspirations, and expectations from the world. If one's understanding of self is absolute, it would help in easily communicating his wants and needs to others. Self-confidence A self-aware state makes one secure and increases confidence. Self-management	Over-thinking Over analysis of situations and prolonged thinking about them will lead to the imagination of unrealistic and unnecessary scenarios, and in extreme cases, may even lead to self-doubt. Arrogance Due to an independent nature and specific approach towards an issue, one may be incorrectly perceived as being arrogant. This is further reinforced by one's tendency to pay attention to every minute detail.

The fact that one is conscious of the indwelling strengths and shortcomings, it equips him to manage his daily affairs efficiently using his strengths to the maximum which in turn compensates for his weaknesses. Self-motivation The absolute knowledge of what one wants out of life will enable the person to strive to achieve those aims and goal while continuously motivating themselves. Yes I can! Focused The qualities of self-motivation and self-management will help develop deeper concentration and direct his focus towards the task at hand. Independence Self-awareness allows the person to be independent. Adaptability The person is highly adaptable to his surroundings as the knowledge of his own qualities allows him to confidently and calmly take decisions and change his approach accordingly in response to situational stimuli.	Wrong assumptions Since there is absence of a feedback, that is, the conversation is in a one-way flow, it could lead to the development of misconceptions and faulty assumptions. Incorrect decisions Prejudices formed based on wrong assumptions made by an individual could lead to incorrect choices or decisions. Yes! No! Categorical thinking There is a possibility of an individual categorizing and viewing certain individuals or events with a biased opinion causing one's thought pattern to be one-tracked and lopsided. N/B: To overcome the disadvantages of intrapersonal communication, it is vital to be aware of one's own surroundings as well. Also, the development of interpersonal communication in addition, could help in overcoming demerits.
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Interpersonal Communication

Interpersonal communication involves interchanging ideas with others using an assortment of methods, such as words, gestures, voice tone, facial expression and body posture. Interpersonal skills are the lifeblood of organizations because effective communication dictates operational efficiency and facilitates teamwork. It underlies the efficiency of key business functions such as managing, training, selling and resolving conflicts within an organization.

Advantages

Interpersonal communication can serve many advantageous purposes.

- It allows us to influence the behavior, attitudes, and opinions of others.
- It allows for more effective, efficient cooperation, and can help us forge or maintain a social bond.
- It can help us learn, and relate to the problems or situations that other individuals face.
- It can help us negotiate, ask for help, offer aid, ask forgiveness, apologize, or achieve reconciliation.
- We may also use interpersonal communication in order to relax and play.
- Is effective to building strong relationships with others.

- Allows others to feel close and connected. When speaking face-to-face, you are able to observe the other person's body language and tone of voice, both valuable clues to the true meaning of the message.
- Most desired method to discuss issues that are highly sensitive.
- Conflict resolution.

Limitations

On the other hand,

- Interpersonal communication takes time, something that most people have little of in this day and age. It is quicker to send a text or email if you only need to share basic information that is impersonal in nature.
- Interpersonal communication is also limited by geography. It is not always feasible to speak face-to-face with everyone you need to communicate with during the day.
- Although once the most desired method of communication, interpersonal communication is being used less frequently due to the technology now available to everyone.